

The Story of NEFREKEPTA

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Preface

The original of this tale is in Demotic Egyptian, in prose, on a fragmentary papyrus dated “the first month of winter, in the fifteenth year” of some king unnamed. Palaeographical evidence suggests some date about 100 BC. My own education has been neglected in the matter of Demotic, and I know the tale only from the literal translation which accompanies the text in Dr. Griffith’s *Stories of the High Priests of Memphis*. In that form, however, it so fascinated me that I presently found myself, to the neglect of more urgent duties, putting it into English verse and filling up the gaps in the narrative. I have tried to preserve the style and often the exact words of the original, as rendered by Dr. Griffith, but in other respects temptations have been great and I have not resisted them.

The names present some difficulties. In Demotic, if I understand aright, the vowels are not written and the consonants often do not mean what they seem to mean. The hero’s name is spelt, roughly speaking, N(’y)-nfr-k’-Pth, the phantom lady’s Ty-bwbwe; the priest’s is written Stne, but was probably pronounced, so Dr. Griffith tells me, Sêtân or Sêtân.

While doing the verses I was constantly reminded of certain Egyptian illuminations by Miss Florence Kingsford, now Mrs. Sydney Cockerell, which I had seen some years ago, and she has been so kind as to provide the book with a frontispiece and tail-piece.¹

Those who desire further information about SETNE will find it in the introduction to Dr. Griffith’s learned and delightful book (Clarendon Press, 1900).

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*G. Murray, *The Story of Nefrekepta, From a Demotic Papyrus*, 1911.

¹These illustrations are not reproduced in this edition.

Introduction

SETNE KHAMUAS, son of RAMESES,
High Priest of ПТАН, beneath his garden trees
Dwelt with his wife and children; wise was he
In Books of power and ancient Masteries.
And much he pondered on a tale they told,
How NEFREKEPTA, dead in days of old,
Held still the Book of HERMES which is THOTH
Hid in his tomb, and never loosed his hold.
And longing for that Book so pierced him through
He called to him his brother AN-HERRU,
The son of MENKH-ART, saying: "Brother mine,
Be with me in a deed I have to do."
And he said: "I am with thee till my doom
Find me." And SETNE said: "I seek the tomb
Of NEFREKEPTA dead, and take the Book,
The Book of THOTH hid in its inmost room."
That night they found the tomb, and AN-HERRU
Stayed at the door, but SETNE passing through
On seven great doors and seven windings spake
His spells, and found the room; and all was true.
For there lay NEFREKEPTA in his pride,
The Book beneath his head; and at his side
The ghosts sate of a woman and a boy,
Shadows beside the dead; and SETNE cried:
"Ye thronèd Shadows, whosoe'er ye be,
And thou, dead PHARAOH, tombed in majesty,
All hail! I, SETNE, scribe and Priest of ПТАН,
Command thy Book be rendered up to me,
The Book of THOTH which lies beneath thy head."
Then never word nor sign came from the dead,
But the two Shadows lifted up their arms
Lamenting, and the woman swift outspread

Her hand to save the Book, and cried: "Aha!
SETNE KHAMUAS, is the will of RA
Not yet fulfilled upon us? This is I,
AHURE of the race of MERNEB-PTAH."

AHURE's Story

"Therefore give ear, and let the Book of Gold
Tempt thee no more, till all my tale be told.—
It happened in the days of MERNEB-PTAH,
The long days, when the King was very old,
And had no son nor daughter; in their room
A son's son and a daughter's daughter, whom
Thou seest, NEFREKEPTA the Good Scribe,
And me who watch beside him in this tomb.
And PHARAOH mused and spake: 'Go near and far,
Bring me the lordliest of my chiefs of war
With all their daughters and their sons, to make
Feast on the third day; call me all that are.'
So PHARAOH spake; but lo, exceedingly
Did I love NEFREKEPTA and he me.
And much I feared that PHARAOH at that feast
Would take some youth and maid of high degree,
A war-lord's daughter and a war-lord's son,
And fast bind NEFREKEPTA to the one,
And me to the other; so his race would grow,
But we two meet no more beneath the sun.
Now PHARAOH's ancient Steward loved me well,
And NEFREKEPTA too; and it befell,
One day he watched me and the second day
He spoke: 'AHURE, surely I can spell
A story that is written in four eyes.
Thou lovest NEFREKEPTA and likewise
He loveth thee.' And I cried out: 'O friend,
Speak unto PHARAOH quick, ere this day dies!

Pray that he give me to my cousin straight,
Nor seek to make us two live separate.'

And he said: 'I will speak; for so the law
Commandeth, by long ages consecrate;
The King's sons wed the daughters of the King.'
Then all my heart was like a water-spring

Leaping; and soon he went and soon returned
Sad, and reported of his counselling:

'I spake to PHARAOH, saying: "Lord, may life
Like RA's be thine and glory in all strife!

Is it not meet that NEFREKEPTA take
By ancient rule AHURE to his wife?

Let PHARAOH wed with PHARAOH; so shall pure
PHARAOH be born:—the rule doth still endure."

And PHARAOH spoke not, but his brow grew dark
With trouble; and I said: "O King, for sure

Thou hast some grief; say what doth vex thy brow?"
And PHARAOH said: "None vexeth me but thou.

I have but two, and if those two be wed
All PHARAOH's fruit is hanging on one bough.

Nay, search and find me one great war-lord's son,
Another war-lord's daughter. With the one

And other let these children twain be wed.
So PHARAOH's line on many threads shall run."

Next day the hours passed and the feast was set
Before the King; and I was called ere yet

The Lords came. And I stood before the King
Not as of old, my heart being desolate.

And PHARAOH spake: "AHURE, was it thou
Didst send that message that hath made my brow

Troubled, that with thy brother thou wouldst wed?"
And I said: "Hath the King not made a vow,

A war-lord's daughter and a war-lord's son—
 Behold us!—Let my brother take the one,
 And let the other take AHURE; so
 Shall PHARAOH's race be great beneath the sun.”
 And there I laughed; and PHARAOH laughed again,
 And called the Steward of the King's domain:
 ‘Steward, this night to NEFREKEPTA's house
 The maid AHURE take and all her train;
 And all things beautiful go with her there.’
 Thus I to NEFREKEPTA's house did fare,
 And PHARAOH sent wrought silver and fine gold,
 And PHARAOH's servants stood about my chair.
 And NEFREKEPTA took with me delight,
 And feasted PHARAOH's servants; and that night
 Was made our marriage, and we knew great joy,
 And never, never, failed I in his sight;
 For each his fellow loved exceedingly.
 And when my time of bearing came to be
 I bore the son who lieth in this tomb,
 MERAB; a name in the Kings' Book is he.”

The Book of THOTH

“And thus it fell, that of all things on earth
 My brother NEFREKEPTA most of worth
 Did hold the wisdom that in Books is writ.
 The tablets of the House of Death and Birth,
 And all that on the temple walls is said,
 And all the lore of the Kings' Tombs he read,
 And ever walked in MEMPHIS on the Hill
 Of Kings, and stored the wisdom of the dead.
 Now one day was a high procession sent
 To PTAH's great house; and NEFREKEPTA went
 And walked therein; right slow he walked, and read
 All that was writ on wall and pediment.

And, watching him, behold, an aged Priest
 Laughed. And he said: 'God's mercy be increased!
 Why laughest thou at me?' And he: 'I laugh
 At no man, not the greatest nor the least;
 I laugh to think how thou shalt laugh anon,
 When that which no man's eye hath looked upon,
 The secret Book of HERMES which is THOTH,
 Is opened to thine hand and called thine own.
 He wrote it, and the Gods before his face
 Fled.—And it lies... If ever word of grace
 Or spell of power thou need, come then to me
 And speak. Thou shalt be guided to the place.
 Two leaves it hath, on which two sorceries
 Are written. If thou read the first of these,
 Thou shalt enchant the earth, the clouds above,
 The underworld, the mountains and the seas;
 And all the words that wingèd things may say,
 And creeping things, shall be made thine that day;
 Yea, thou shalt see all fishes in the deep
 And God's power guiding each upon his way.
 And if thou read the second, though there lies
 Above thee all AMENTI, thou shalt rise
 And take thy shape again, and see the Moon
 And RA and all the children of the skies.'
 And NEFREKEPTA cried: 'O Priest and King!
 I bless thee. Tell me every gorgeous thing
 Thy soul desireth, they shall all be thine,
 Wilt thou but guide my steps to that great spring.'
 Then smiled the Priest: 'My Prince, so let it be!
 Send me an hundred bars of silver, free
 Of all fault, for my burial when I die;
 And two full priesthoods give me without fee.'

And NEFREKEPTA called a youth, and bade
 An hundred bars of silver pure be made,
 And two new priesthoods named to THOTH and PTAH,
 And sealed him priest to PTAH and THOTH unpaid.
 Then the man spoke: 'The Book of THOTH doth rest
 In COPTOS Sea, hid in a golden chest;
 The gold doth lie in silver; that in wrought
 Ebon and ivory, fitted nest in nest;
 That in sweet cedar; that in bronze doth lie;
 The bronze in iron. 'Tis knotted with a ply
 Of endless Snake; and round it for one league
 Are scorpion, asp, and worm to make men die.'
 He spoke, and NEFREKEPTA no more knew
 What place he stood in nor what breath he drew,
 But forth he hied him in great joy, and caught
 My hand, and all this tale he told me true;
 And cried: 'South, South to COPTOS! None shall stay
 Our going.' But I turned from him away
 And found that aged Priest and said: 'Thou Priest,
 May AMUN curse thee for thy words this day!
 The Book of THOTH, the serpents and the sea!
 Most bitter striving thou hast made for me,
 And bitter watching till my lord's return;
 False art thou, and thy South all cruelty.'
 And much I prayed my brother not to sail
 To COPTOS, but my prayer might not avail,
 For straight to PHARAOH's throne he went, and spake
 To PHARAOH of the Priest and all his tale.
 And PHARAOH said: 'What wilt thou I should do?'
 'Give me thy ship of pleasure and its crew,'
 He said: 'and with me let AHURE sail
 To find the Book, and the boy MERAB too.'

So PHARAOH's pleasure-ship was brought, and all
Its crew; and southward in high festival

 We sailed to COPTOS; and the news went forth
Before us, and the folk stood on the wall.

The Priests of ISIS and HARPOCRATES
And the Chief Priest of ISIS, all of these

 Came down to NEFREKEPTA, and to me
The women of the Priests in their degrees.

They led us to their Temple in a line;
And NEFREKEPTA gave ox, goose, and wine,

 And brought to ISIS and HARPOCRATES
Rite and oblation and all dues divine.

A temple beautiful exceedingly
Was over us, and there four days did he

 Make with the Priests of ISIS holiday,
And the priests' women holiday with me.

But when the morning of the fifth day came,
He called for wax made holy, without blame,

 And shaped a boat with men, and spake a spell,
And breathed; and life woke in them like a flame.

He went on board that boat, and heaped it high
With sand, and pushed it from the shore. And I

 Sate on the shore alone, and said: 'I wait
Here till he comes, and if he dies I die.'

He said: 'O Rowers, row me to the place
I wot of.' And the rowers rowed apace,

 By day, by night, and ceased on the third day.
Then he took sand, and cast the sand a space

Before him, and the water rose on both
Sides, and the floor below did ooze and froth

 With scorpion, asp, and worm to make men die,
One league before the treasure chest of THOTH.

And round the chest was coiled an endless Snake.
 Then NEFREKEPTA took his charms, and spake
 A spell on all that league of serpent things,
 And down they sank, and slept, and could not wake.
 Then o'er the league of asps he walked, and fought
 With the endless Snake and slew it; but it caught
 Life as it fell, and joined again and flew
 To tear him; and again its death he wrought;
 Then a third time it quickened, and again
 He fought and smote the endless Snake in twain
 The third time; and between the parts he cast
 Fine sand; and it lay still, for ever slain.
 And on he strode and found the caskets, rolled
 Each within each; iron the outmost fold,
 Then bronze; then cedar; then came ivory
 And ebon; then the silver; then the gold.
 He broke the gold, and kneeling on his knees
 Read out the first of the two sorceries,
 Enchanting all the earth, the clouds above,
 The underworld, the mountains and the seas.
 And everything that bird or worm might say,
 Or mountain beast, he heard and knew that day,
 And saw all fishes moving in the deep,
 And God's power guiding each upon its way.
 He read the second sorcery, and far
 In heaven he saw the shining forth of RA,
 And all his Children round him, and the Moon
 Uprising, and the shape of every Star.
 And NEFREKEPTA shut the Book, and then
 Went to his boat and called the magic men:
 'Row day, row night, and row me to the shore.'
 So rowed they, and he reached the shore again.

And found me sitting by the sea to wait
 His coming. Seven full days and nights I sate,
 And ate nor drank, but waited, and was grown
 Like them they bear to the embalmer's gate.

 I said to him: 'My brother, let me see
 The Book that wrought such pain on thee and me.'
 He gave the Book into my hands, and slow
 I read what there was writ of sorcery.

 I laid upon the earth and sky my spell,
 The underworld, the hills, the ocean swell;
 And understood what tales the birds of heaven
 And mountain beasts and deep-sea fishes tell.

 Then did I read the second spell, and high
 Above saw RA enthronèd in the sky,
 And all his Children; and I saw the Moon
 And all the Stars in all their shapes go by.

 And NEFREKEPTA bade them bring a roll
 Of new papyrus, and wrote out the whole
 Of those two charms, and melted it in wine,
 And drank it. So the charm was in his soul.

 Then sacrifice we made and gifts of worth
 Heaped high in all the temples, and set forth
 On PHARAOH's ship with singing and great joy,
 One league, one league, from COPTOS to the North.

 But THOTH himself had seen our deed, and, ah,
 His wrath was hot! Before the throne of RA,
 'Judgement!' he cried, 'Give judgement between me
 And NEFREKEPTA, son of MERNEB-PTAH,

 Who broke into my treasure-house this day,
 And slew my Snake and stole my Book away.'
 And RA said: 'Surely he is in thy hand,
 O THOTH, both he and his, to spare or slay.'

And lo, a Power of God went forth, and fell
 On all the river and lay invisible;
 And THOTH said: 'NEFREKEPTA shall come home
 No more, nor one of those that with him dwell.'
 Then the boy MERAB, singing, from the shade
 Of PHARAOH's awning stepped; one step he made,
 And, lo, the River took him, and his face
 Was covered and the will of RA obeyed.
 Then all about us cried with a great cry.
 But NEFREKEPTA from his awning high
 Called with a spell, and the dead boy rose up;
 But over him that Power of God did lie.
 Then NEFREKEPTA spake a written spell,
 And the boy MERAB told all that befell
 About him; yea, the very words which THOTH
 Spake at the throne of RA he made him tell.
 Then slow to COPTOS we returned, and bore
 The boy MERAB to the embalmer's door;
 And like a Prince he was embalmed and laid
 On COPTOS Hill with the great dead of yore.
 And NEFREKEPTA said: 'My sister, come
 Quick; let us row till all the road be foam,
 Lest PHARAOH hear what hath befallen us,
 And his heart faint because we come not home.'
 We went on board, and northward rowed apace
 One league from COPTOS; and I saw the place
 Where MERAB died, and from the canopy
 Stepped, and the River took me; and my face
 Was covered and the will of RA obeyed.
 Then all upon the boat great mourning made,
 But NEFREKEPTA from his awning high
 Called, and I knew a spell upon me laid;

And I rose up, though o'er me still had hold
 That Power of God. I rose and did unfold
 All that befell me, yea, and every word
 Which THOTH before RA's throne had spoke I told.
 Then slow to COPTOS he returned and bore
 Me, his dead sister, to the embalmer's door;
 And like a Queen I was embalmed, and laid
 Where MERAB my dead child was laid before.
 He went on board, and down the stream apace
 Rowed one league north from COPTOS, to the place
 Where MERAB died and I, AHURE, died;
 And stood and communed with his heart a space:
 'Shall it be backward now, ere THOTH can slay?
 Shall it be on to PHARAOH, come what may?
 And, lo, when PHARAOH asks me where those two,
 His children, are, what is it I shall say?
 "I took thy children to a burning land
 And living let them die; and here I stand."
 I will not speak it.'—Then he bade them bring
 A band of finest linen, such a band
 As dead kings wear, to bind them at the last;
 And seven times round his body made it fast,
 And close against his body bound the Book
 Firm; and from out the canopy he passed.
 And, lo, the River took him, and the will
 Of RA was done. And they on board did fill
 The air with wailing: 'Great woe! Grievous woe!
 Dead, dead, is the Good Scribe and all his skill.'
 And down the stream the pleasure-ship sailed on
 Toward MEMPHIS, and to no man there was known
 Where NEFREKEPTA lay; and when they came
 Message was brought to PHARAOH on his throne.

And PHARAOH came in robes of funeral,
 And all the folk of MEMPHIS, great and small,
 And PTAH's High Priest and all the Priests of PTAH,
 And PHARAOH's council and his household, all;

 And saw the ship, and, lo, beneath it drowned
 Saw NEFREKEPTA lying, both hands wound
 About the rudder, guiding still his ship;
 So great a scribe was NEFREKEPTA found.

 They raised him, and against his body dead
 They found the Book pressed close. And PHARAOH said:
 'Behold the Book he died for! Let it lie
 In this King's grave, a pillow for his head.'

 Then sixteen days embalming did they keep
 For NEFREKEPTA, thirty-five of deep
 Wrapping; of burial threescore days and ten;
 And here he resteth in the House of Sleep.

 And I, AHURE, far away must lie
 In COPTOS; but my heart within doth cry
 For NEFREKEPTA, and our shadows come
 Waking and watch beside him sleeplessly."

The Contest for the Book

"And thou, SETNE KHAMUAS, who dost look
 To take from us that which from THOTH we took,
 Where hast thou paid the price?—These twain and I,
 Our lives on earth were taken for this Book."

 But SETNE said: "AHURE, none the less,
 For all thy tale of old unhappiness,
 Yield me the Book at NEFREKEPTA's head:
 I take it else by wrath and bitter stress."

 Then NEFREKEPTA from his marble bed
 Rose up: "O thou to whom my wife hath said
 Words vainly wise, and thou hast hearkened not,
 How wilt thou win the Book beneath my head?

Think'st thou to take it from me by the wit
 Of a good scribe? Or wilt thou play for it
 Four games of draughts, the fifty points and two?"
 And SETNE said: "The draughts;" and down did sit.
 Between them then the gaming board they drew
 For the first game of fifty points and two;
 And NEFREKEPTA won the game, and spake
 A spell, and with the board he ruled it true.
 And SETNE ankle-deep into the floor
 Sank. And again they played, and as before
 Dead NEFREKEPTA won the second game;
 And SETNE sank up to the thighs and more.
 Again they played; and NEFREKEPTA dead
 Won the third game; and SETNE to his head
 Sank, and the earth came close below his ears.
 And SETNE lifted up his voice in dread:
 "Brother, where art thou? Brother AN-HERRU,
 Bear word to PHARAOH of the deeds I do.
 Pray PHARAOH the last amulets of PTAH
 Be sent me. Haste! Haste!"—Then the dead man drew
 The board up close, and the fourth game began.
 And AN-HERRU far off had heard, and ran,
 Ran unto PHARAOH's throne and told his tale.
 And PHARAOH said: "To save a sinking man
 Take the last amulets!" And AN-HERRU
 Flew with them to the dead man's gate, and flew
 Through all the windings, all the doors, and, lo,
 The game was playing still between those two.
 He laid the amulets on SETNE's head,
 And SETNE shivered in the earth, and said
 A great spell; then, upstriving from the ground,
 Reached out his arm, and caught the Book, and fled.

Light went before him, and behind great gloom
Closed, and he heard AHURE for her doom
 Wailing: "King Darkness, come! King Light, farewell!
Gone, gone, is the last comfort of the Tomb."
But NEFREKEPTA on his marble bed
Lay back and laughed: "A little while," he said,
 "O Shadow of my Sister, and this man
Shall come again. Therefore be comforted.
His dreams shall bring him back, before mine ire
Kneeling, to do the worst of our desire,
 A fork upon his neck, a rod between
His hands, and on his head a bowl of fire."

TA-BUVUE, and the Return of the Book

But SETNE out into the light above
Returned, and saw the light with a great love;
 And sealed the tomb, and stood at PHARAOH's throne
And told his doings and the end thereof.
And PHARAOH said to SETNE: "These be vain
Doings. Go back and give the dead again
 His book, as a wise man to a wise man,
Now, lest thou give it some day with much pain."
But SETNE hearkened not. By day and night
He read the Book and took therein delight,
 And showed it at his feasts; and all his days
Were sweet to SETNE and his breath was light.
'Twas joy to read, joy also when he made
Mirth with his sons, joy when he rose and prayed
 In ПТАН's great Temple; till one day, behold,
In ПТАН's great Temple, through the colonnade,
A troop of damsels fair exceedingly,
And one who led them. Beautiful was she,
 And not like other women; good beyond
All he had seen or ever thought to see.

Her girdle was of gold and gold her hood,
 And all that touched her fragrant was and good,
 And maids behind her fifty walked and two;
 And, seeing, SETNE wist not where he stood,
 But called the Slave that served him: "Haste thee, go
 To where yon woman worships; I would know
 What need hath brought her and what name she bears.
 Go swiftly." And the servant bowed him low,
 And found a handmaiden who walked aside:
 "Damsel, thy mistress cometh in much pride;
 Say by what name men call her, and what need
 Brings her to MEMPHIS." And the maid replied:
 "This is the child of the Chief Vision Seer
 Of BAST, Queen of the Far World and the Near;
 Her name is TA-BUVUË, and a vow
 To PTAH, your mighty God, hath brought her here."
 The slave returned and told to SETNE all
 The handmaid spoke; and SETNE said: "Go, call
 This handmaid secretly behind the rest;
 Greet her from me and speak my name withal:
 'SETNE KHAMUAS, son of RAMESSES,
 Greet thee: he sends ten gold Arsinoës;
 And more, if any man hath done thee wrong,
 SETNE the judge will right thine injuries;
 All this, if thou wilt speak with him an hour,
 And help him. To a great and secret tower
 Thou shalt go in, where none shall do thee hurt
 Nor know thy name; so great is SETNE's power."
 The slave returned and all of SETNE's word
 Told to the handmaid; and her wrath was stirred,
 And loud she railed, as though 'twere blasphemies
 His lips had spoke; and TA-BUVUË heard,

And called him: "Strive not with this foolish one;
But hither, tell to me what wrong is done."

But quick the handmaid ran before, and cried:
"He bringeth words of shame from PHARAOH's son:

Thus saying: 'SETNE, son of RAMESES,
Greets thee, and sends ten gold Arsinoës;

And more, if any man hath done thee wrong,
SETNE the judge will right thine injuries;'

All this, if I will speak with him an hour
And help him. To a great and secret tower

I shall go in, where none shall do me hurt
Nor know my name; so great is SETNE's power!"

Then TA-BUVUË laughed: "I think he spake
This word to thee for TA-BUVUË's sake.—

Go, speak to SETNE, saying: 'Who am I
That thou shouldst send my bondmaid gifts to take?

I am no common woman; I am one
Born of great kings, who walk my ways alone,
Priestess of BAST, the Queen of the Two Worlds,
And seeking no man's gift and fearing none.

If me thou seekest, I will speak within
Mine own house: knock and thou shalt enter in:

In PER-BAST, by the Houses of the Dead,
Past KEMI, where the desert doth begin.

There ask for TA-BUVUË. I go hence
Now with my maids to make magnificence

Before thee. And no man shall watch thy way
Into my house, nor mark thy coming thence."

The Slave returned, and SETNE's heart did fail
For very joy at hearing of the tale.

He called his servants: "Make me a swift boat
Ready, with rowers and a silken sail."

And SETNE marvelled in his heart a space,
And in his mirror looked; and, lo, his face
 Seemed beautiful again, and all his limbs
Light, like a young man when he runs a race.
So walked he to the boat and entered in,
And bade them row as ne'er they rowed, to win
 PER-BAST, beyond the Houses of the Dead,
Past KEMI, where the desert doth begin.
And there, behold, a tower exceeding tall
Set in a pleasant place; and a great wall
 Was round it, and a garden to the north
With many trees. And SETNE gave a call:
"Whose is this tower?" And heard an answer: "Here
Dwells TA-BUVUË, daughter of the Seer
 Of BAST, she who is named The Beautiful."
And SETNE entered and no man was near.
And up the garden ways he went, and cast
His eyes on all and marvelled as he passed:
 And TA-BUVUË came and held his hand
And spoke: "Now by the Holiness of BAST,
This day is happiness. Come to mine high
Chamber, we two alone amid the sky."
 So up the stair they went, to a cool room
Of turquoise wrought and lapis lazuli.
Couches were there, decked with fair linen strand
Like PHARAOH's couch; and cups of gold did stand
 On a great dresser, and a cup of gold
Was filled with wine and laid in SETNE's hand.
And TA-BUVUË said: "Take wine and meat."
But he said: "Love, how could I drink or eat?"
 Then in a censer burning gums they brought
And spices rare and unguent for his feet.

Lo, none was like her, none that bore the name
 Of woman! And his heart rose like a flame:
 “O TA-BUVUË, let the end be now:
 Let us make perfect that for which we came!”
 “Is not this house thine own and I thy bride?”
 Said she: “Yet one thing first shalt thou decide.
 I am no common woman, but to BAST
 Pure, and full-filled of majesty and pride.
 Thy present wife put from thee, that no soul
 Near me may stand; and write it in a scroll.
 And all thy wealth of Priesthoods and of Powers,
 With me alone thou shalt divide the whole.”
 Said SETNE: “Call a scribe.” And at their call
 The scribe came; and he wrote a scroll withal
 And cast off SETNE’s wife; and SETNE’s wealth,
 With TA-BUVUË did he share it all.
 And in that hour one spoke to SETNE: “Lo,
 Thy children, waiting in the court below,
 Sit with the dogs and curling cats of BAST.”
 And SETNE said: “Bring them, and let them know.”
 Then TA-BUVUË laid her raiment proud
 Off, and put on soft linen, like one vowed
 To bridal; and her body through the robe
 Shone, as the moon shines through a little cloud.
 And back she turned to him and poured him wine,
 And said: “These children must not strive with mine.
 Make them to sign the scroll, too, and give up
 Their part in thee.” And SETNE made them sign.
 The fine, fine, linen robed her like a mist
 Which robeth RA in pearl and amethyst;
 And SETNE marvelled gazing; and again
 She spoke, and SETNE’s hand she took and kissed:

“These children, knowing all to me thou art,
Hate me.—Let them be mine to take apart
And do my will upon them.” And he said:
“Do all the abomination of thy heart.”

She slew them then, and from her window fine
Cast them. And far below he heard the whine
Of dogs that tore and curling cats of BAST
Which lapped their blood. And SETNE drank his wine.

He said: “Those children that were slain had birth
By me. O Woman, thou hast made much dearth
About me. Give me that for which I came,
Else have I nothing, nothing, on this earth.”

“Hast thou not me,” she said, “in place of all?
Come, therefore!” And she led him through the hall
To a fair couch, ebon and ivory;
And down he lay, and spread swift arms withal

To clasp her; and within his arms outspread,
Behold, she withered, withered; and her head
It had no eyes, and downward all her jaw
Dropped, like the jaws of the uncared-for dead.

And SETNE strove to rise, but cloud on cloud
Held him: hot wind and hate and laughter loud,
And one that wept for a world’s glory gone,
And dust, dust, dust: and SETNE shrieked aloud:

And saw: and, lo, all naked in the day
In a waste place of bricks and shards he lay,
And clutched a burning kiln. And near him passed
The way and much folk jeering on the way,

Soldiers and priests, beggars and men of pride.
And SETNE rolled him in the dust and cried:

“My children!” And a great lord rose in wrath:
“Thy children stand this hour at PHARAOH’s side,

Thou naked man! Thou Priest whom none shall bless!
And ask for thee. What? Is it drunkenness?"

And SETNE said: "They live." And said: "O King,
Throw me, I pray, some robe in this distress,

Wrought by dead NEFREKEPTA in his ire.

I go to yield him up his worst desire,

A fork upon my neck, between my hands
A rod, and on my head a bowl of fire."

One of the bondmen threw him, at that call,

A poor man's robe; and on to PHARAOH's Hall

He journeyed with them, and stretched out his arms
And clasped his sons, and told to PHARAOH all.

"Yea, take the Book, take quickly," PHARAOH said,

"The rod, the fork, the fire upon thine head,

And seek dead NEFREKEPTA in his tomb,
And kneel and pray the pardon of the dead."

And SETNE heard; and quick ere set of sun

He stood before the Tomb, and one by one

Passed the great doors, and opened the last door,
And, lo, a light through all the chamber shone,

A great light, like the going forth of RA.

And while he stood the Woman cried: "Aha,

SETNE, thou com'st! And if thou com'st alive
'Tis PTAH hath saved thee and the grace of PTAH."

But NEFREKEPTA laughed. And SETNE came

Kneeling: "O King, with rod and fork and flame

I come," he said; "and yield thee up thy Book.
What is thy judgement? Is it further shame?"

But NEFREKEPTA laughed: "I would not now

Make thee my slave, nor smite, nor burn thy brow.

This was enough.—Yet one thing lacketh me
Still, and thereto I bind thee by a vow.

Far off in a strange grave 'mid much annoy
 My wife AHURE lieth and the boy
 MERAB; 'tis but their shadows, by the art
 Of a good scribe, dwell here and have no joy.
 Therefore I charge upon thee my behest:
 Go, bring from COPTOS to this House of Rest
 My wife AHURE and MERAB the boy."
 And SETNE rose and took on him the quest.
 And straightway before PHARAOH bowed his head
 And told him all the tale. And PHARAOH said:
 "I give thee mine own pleasure-ship to sail
 To COPTOS and bring back those ancient dead."
 So PHARAOH's pleasure-ship with all its crew
 Was brought, and southward on the wind they flew
 To COPTOS; and the High Priest saw the ship,
 And all the Priests, and came in haste thereto.
 The Priests of ISIS and HARPOCRATES
 And the Chief Priest; SETNE to all of these
 Gave ox and goose and wine, and with them walked
 On COPTOS Hill amid the tombs and trees.
 Three days and nights among the tombs they trod
 In COPTOS on the Hill, and every sod
 They turned and marked, and every graven stone,
 And the Scribes' writings in the House of God.
 But never could they find by night nor day
 The tomb where MERAB and AHURE lay.
 And NEFREKEPTA knew they found it not,
 And sent his shadow forth to guide their way.
 Like an old man, a bent and aged Priest,
 It sate. And SETNE said: "Joy be increased,
 O Father! Thou dost know the things of old;
 Three days and nights we search, and have not ceased,

To find the tomb which holds AHURE dead
 And MERAB." Then the old man raised his head:
 "The father of my grandsire in old days
 Spoke of it to my grandsire; and he said
 The father of his grandsire once had told
 His grandsire how those two were laid of old
 Far in the southmost corner, where the house
 Now stands in which the scrivener tells his gold."
 And SETNE said: "Old man, methinks I see
 Some hate here. Hath the scrivener injured thee,
 That thou wouldst wreck his house and dig beneath?"
 He answered: "Have a watch set over me;
 Then raze the scrivener's house, and, under ground
 By the south corner, if there be not found
 Both MERAB and AHURE, have me slain!"
 So there they held him and a guard stood round.
 The scrivener's house was razed; and that same day
 They found where MERAB and AHURE lay,
 And, like great PHARAOHS, down to PHARAOH's boat
 Bore them 'mid Priests and Princes in array.
 And SETNE sought that ancient man, and, lo,
 He was not. By that sign did SETNE know
 This too was NEFREKEPTA. Then they built
 The scrivener's house again, and turned to go:
 And went on board, and back to MEMPHIS bore
 Those PHARAOHS home, with stream and wind and oar;
 Singing they went, and PHARAOH heard them sing;
 And PHARAOH rose and met them by the shore,
 And led those Mighty Ones in robes of pride
 To NEFREKEPTA's tomb, and sanctified
 Their entering in, and made a mound above;
 And there for ever sleep they, side by side.

And there is finished all that fell between
SETNE and NEFREKEPTA and his Queen
AHURE and the boy MERAB. 'Twas writ
In the first month of winter, Year xv.